

ISMUN 4.0

BACKGROUND GUIDE



JOINT CRISIS

COMMITTEE:

CHINESE CABINET

Agenda: *Crisis Management of Taiwan-Chinese Conflict*

Simulation Year: 2028

LETTER FROM THE EXECUTIVE BOARD

Si vis pacem, para bellum

Dear delegates,

Each generation believes that they will be the last, ours has very impressive statistics to support this claim; however, it is up to us to decide if we make the claim come true or turn it in our favour.

With that, on behalf of the Executive Board, we extend a warm welcome to all of you and congratulate you on being part of the first edition of JCC in the fourth edition of the ISMUN. We assure you that this committee will be highly stimulating and make you think on your feet throughout both days of deliberation. We are sure that this background guide will provide you with the perfect launching pad as it encompasses a plethora of information that we believe will help you kickstart your research.

However, that being said, please do not limit your research to only what is provided here but ensure that you logically deduce and push your research to areas associated with the issues mentioned. Our agenda is multifaceted with layers that involve deep diving into them. During the committee we would look upon creativity, unique ideas, and no repetition of pre-existing solutions. It would also be preferred if delegates would be spontaneous in nature regarding their speeches and other committee statements, as that would also be most fitting with how we will be planning the flow of the committee.

We encourage you to be bold and confident. Speak up, challenge ideas, and bring new perspectives that can change the discussion. The best debates come from delegates who dare to push limits, question common beliefs, and think creatively. Use this chance to make your voice heard, it is through fearless speaking that real change begins.

Lastly, remember to have fun and enjoy the feeling of being in a continuous crisis committee, we promise not to disappoint.

Until October.

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INTRODUCTION TO THE COMMITTEE

A Joint Crisis Committee (JCC) differs from a conventional General Assembly or Security Council simulation because delegates are not merely debating a predetermined resolution. They are expected to manage an evolving crisis through continuous decision-making.

The Chinese Cabinet in this simulation represents the principal decision-making structure of the People's Republic of China during a rapidly developing Taiwan Strait crisis. Delegates therefore operate from the perspective of Chinese state institutions and must consider political, military, diplomatic, economic and domestic consequences simultaneously.

The committee is designed around the idea that a crisis rarely develops along a single track. A political announcement may generate a diplomatic reaction; a diplomatic reaction may produce military signalling; military signalling may affect financial markets and shipping; economic disruption may then create additional political pressure.

1. Taiwanese Cabinet (ROC)

Represents the national leadership in Taipei: the President, defense officials, intelligence heads, foreign diplomats, economic ministers, and regional partner liaisons (USA, Japan, Australia, India). Your goal is to safeguard Taiwan's democracy, protect civilian lives, maintain trade, and deter aggression without accidentally triggering World War III.

2. Chinese Cabinet (PRC)

Represents the central government in Beijing: the Central Military Commission, Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Ministry of State Security, and economic planners. Their mandate is to uphold Beijing's sovereignty claim over Taiwan, counter foreign intervention, and apply escalating political and military pressure.

INTRODUCTION TO THE AGENDA

The Taiwan Strait crisis is rooted in the unresolved consequences of the Chinese Civil War and the subsequent separation of political authority between mainland China and Taiwan.

In 1949, the Chinese Communist Party established the People's Republic of China (PRC) on the mainland, while the government of the Republic of China (ROC), led by Chiang Kai-shek and the Kuomintang (KMT), retreated to Taiwan. Both governments historically claimed legitimacy over China. Over time, however, the political systems, institutions and identities on either side of the Strait developed in different directions.

From Beijing's perspective, Taiwan remains part of China and the Taiwan question is fundamentally connected to sovereignty, territorial integrity and national reunification. China's official position continues to emphasise the **One-China Principle** and describes peaceful reunification as the preferred approach. China's 2022 white paper states that peaceful reunification and the "One Country, Two Systems" framework constitute the basic principles proposed for resolving the Taiwan question.

At the same time, Taiwan has developed a separate political system, armed forces, economy and democratic institutions. The island's democratisation, particularly after the lifting of martial law in 1987, contributed to the development of a distinct Taiwanese political identity.

This has transformed the dispute. The issue is no longer simply a question of competing governments claiming to represent China. It also involves:

- sovereignty and territorial integrity;
- political identity;
- the future political system of Taiwan;
- military deterrence;
- international recognition;
- relations between China and the United States;
- regional security;
- international law;
- trade and shipping;
- semiconductor supply chains;

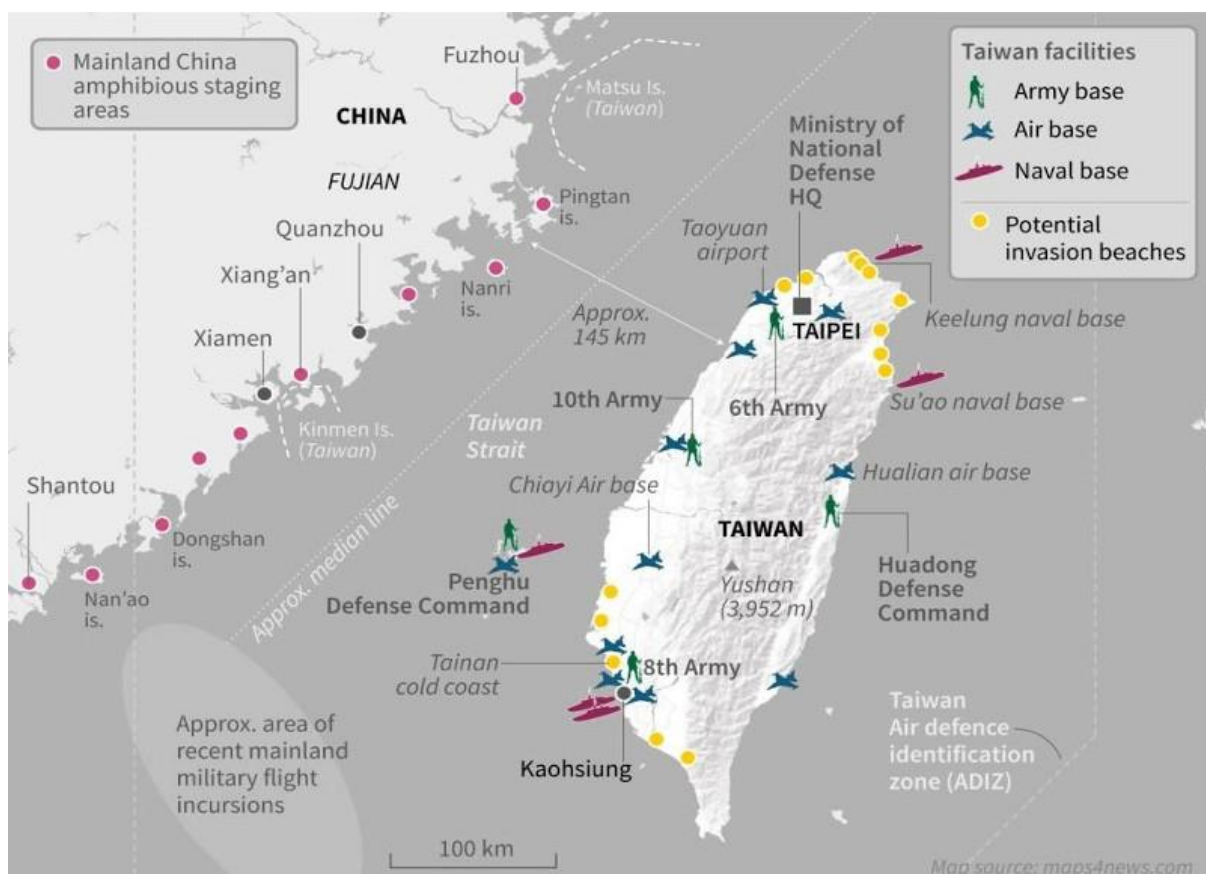
- civilian protection; and
- information and cyber security.

The international dimension developed further during the Cold War. In 1971, United Nations General Assembly Resolution 2758 restored the PRC's representation in the United Nations and expelled the representatives of Chiang Kai-shek. China interprets the resolution as confirming the One-China Principle, while debates remain internationally over the precise scope of what Resolution 2758 itself determines concerning Taiwan.

The United States subsequently established diplomatic relations with the PRC in 1979 while maintaining unofficial relations with Taiwan under a deliberately complex framework. This strategic ambiguity has remained an important component of cross-Strait stability. The committee guide describes this arrangement as one that neither endorsed Taiwanese independence nor accepted forced reunification.

The Taiwan Strait is therefore best understood as a **crisis-management problem rather than a single territorial dispute**.

The central challenge for the Chinese Cabinet is consequently to pursue its stated objectives while managing the possibility of escalation, internationalisation and economic disruption.



HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

Imperial and Colonial Background

The historical significance of Taiwan is connected to the wider history of China and East Asia. During the nineteenth century, Qing China experienced increasing foreign intervention and territorial pressure. The Opium Wars and subsequent unequal treaties weakened Qing sovereignty and contributed to what Chinese historical narratives describe as the "Century of Humiliation." The First Sino-Japanese War of 1894–95 further altered the regional balance.

Following China's defeat, Taiwan was ceded to Japan in 1895. Japanese rule lasted until the end of the Second World War.

These historical experiences later became important to Chinese nationalist narratives surrounding sovereignty and territorial integrity.

The Chinese Civil War

The modern political division emerged primarily from the Chinese Civil War. The Chinese Communist Party (CCP) and the Kuomintang (KMT) had previously cooperated during parts of the struggle against foreign invasion, but their relationship deteriorated substantially during the late 1920s. After years of conflict, the CCP under Mao Zedong emerged victorious on the mainland in 1949.

On 1 October 1949, the People's Republic of China was established in Beijing. The ROC government subsequently relocated to Taiwan.

The two governments initially continued to claim that they represented China as a whole. Thus, the division was not originally understood by either side simply as the creation of two independent states. This historical foundation remains central to China's official position today. Chinese government documents describe the Taiwan question as a consequence of the Chinese Civil War and argue that the establishment of the PRC represented a change of government within one China rather than the creation of a separate Chinese state.

The Cold War and the First Taiwan Strait Crises

The emerging division became internationalised during the Cold War.

The Korean War in 1950 increased American involvement in East Asian security. The United States deployed naval forces around Taiwan, while Beijing viewed American involvement as external interference preventing reunification.

The First Taiwan Strait Crisis began in 1954 when conflict developed around offshore islands controlled by the ROC, particularly Kinmen and Matsu. A second crisis followed in 1958.

These crises demonstrated that the Taiwan question could rapidly involve major powers and potentially escalate beyond the immediate geographical area.

They also established a recurring pattern:

political pressure → military signalling → external intervention → heightened risk of escalation.

International Representation and Resolution 2758

For much of the early Cold War, the ROC government retained China's seat at the United Nations.

However, international recognition gradually shifted towards the PRC as more states recognised Beijing as the government representing China.

In October 1971, the UN General Assembly adopted Resolution 2758, restoring the PRC's lawful rights in the United Nations and recognising the representatives of its government as the legitimate representatives of China.

The resolution fundamentally changed Taiwan's position within the international system.

Beijing interprets Resolution 2758 as confirming the One-China Principle and the PRC's representation of China, including Taiwan. Other governments and legal scholars have debated the extent to which the resolution itself determines Taiwan's sovereignty or international legal status.

US-China Normalisation

The United States formally recognised the PRC in 1979.

The US simultaneously maintained unofficial relations with Taiwan and established the Taiwan Relations Act.

This created a complicated strategic structure in which Washington recognised Beijing diplomatically while continuing substantial unofficial political, economic and security relations with Taiwan.

The resulting ambiguity became a major component of deterrence in the Strait.

For Beijing, American involvement remains closely connected to the question of reunification and foreign interference.

For Washington, Taiwan has remained important to regional stability and the wider balance of power in the Western Pacific.

Democratisation of Taiwan

One of the most significant developments after the Cold War was Taiwan's political transformation.

Martial law was lifted in 1987. Opposition political activity expanded, press restrictions decreased and democratic institutions developed.

Taiwan subsequently held increasingly competitive elections, culminating in its first direct presidential election in 1996.

This transformation affected the political nature of the cross-Strait dispute. The population living on Taiwan increasingly became an important political actor in determining the island's future.

The study guide notes that democratic development contributed to a distinct Taiwanese identity and changed the political calculations surrounding reunification.

The Third Taiwan Strait Crisis

The Third Taiwan Strait Crisis occurred during 1995–96.

Taiwanese President Lee Teng-hui's visit to the United States was interpreted by Beijing as a challenge to the existing political framework. China conducted missile tests and large-scale military exercises around Taiwan.

The crisis coincided with Taiwan's first direct presidential election.

The United States responded by deploying two aircraft carrier battle groups to the region. The crisis ultimately ended without direct war.

The episode had long-term consequences.

China accelerated military modernisation, Taiwan strengthened its defence capabilities and Washington demonstrated that a Taiwan crisis could generate direct American military involvement.

Cross-Strait Economic Integration

Despite political tensions, economic links between mainland China and Taiwan expanded substantially after the 1990s.

Trade, investment and business relationships created significant economic interdependence.

This produced an important contradiction:

the same relationship could simultaneously reduce incentives for conflict and create strategic vulnerabilities.

Economic integration could provide incentives for stability, but it could also become a source of leverage during a crisis.

Recent Escalation

Political tensions increased significantly during the 2020s.

Taiwan's domestic politics, US-China strategic competition and increasingly frequent Chinese military activity around Taiwan contributed to a more difficult security environment.

The 2022 visit of US House Speaker Nancy Pelosi to Taiwan was followed by large-scale Chinese military exercises around the island. The episode demonstrated how a political event could rapidly generate military consequences.

The committee study guide presents the current environment as one characterised by repeated military exercises, political mistrust, competing interpretations of sovereignty and limited diplomatic space.

The simulation begins in 2028, but delegates should not assume that every future development is predetermined. The crisis is intentionally designed to evolve through committee action.

TIMELINE OF MAJOR DEVELOPMENTS

Year / Era	Historical Milestone	Why It Matters to Our 2028 Cabinet
1949	The Chinese Civil War concludes on the mainland. Mao Zedong establishes the PRC in Beijing. Chiang Kai-shek relocates the ROC government to Taiwan.	Created the modern political division: two rival governments governing two separate geographic territories.
1954–1958	First & Second Taiwan Strait Crises: Heavy PLA artillery bombardments strike Taiwan's frontline islands of Kinmen and Matsu.	Prompted the 1954 US-ROC Mutual Defense Treaty and established the strategic vulnerability of outlying frontline islands.
1971	UN General Assembly Resolution 2758: The UN recognizes the PRC as the only legitimate representative of China to the UN.	The ROC lost its UN seat. Today, Taiwan is excluded from international bodies like the WHO and ICAO despite governing 23.5 million people.
1979	The US formally normalizes diplomatic relations with Beijing, severing official ties with Taipei. The US Congress passes the Taiwan Relations Act (TRA) .	The TRA legally obligates the US to provide Taiwan with arms of a defensive character and to maintain the US capacity to resist coercion.
1995–1996	Third Taiwan Strait Crisis: China conducts missile tests near Keelung and Kaohsiung ports. US President Clinton deploys two aircraft carrier battle groups.	Showcased US willingness to intervene militarily and accelerated PLA naval and missile modernization to counter US naval power.
1996	Taiwan holds its first direct, democratic presidential election; Lee Teng-hui is elected.	Transformed Taiwan into an open, multiparty democracy, deepening the identity of its citizens as distinct from authoritarian governance.

2016–2020	Tsai Ing-wen is elected President. Beijing freezes high-level communication. The 2019 Hong Kong crackdown discredits the "One Country, Two Systems" framework in Taiwan.	Official government-to-government hotlines between Taipei and Beijing were severed, increasing the danger of miscalculation during the crisis.
August 2022	US House Speaker Nancy Pelosi visits Taipei. The PLA responds with live-fire drills surrounding Taiwan and routinely crosses the median line.	Dismantled the historical buffer zone of the Strait Median Line; normalized high-intensity Chinese military operations near Taiwan's coast.
2024	Lai Ching-te is inaugurated as President. Beijing conducts large-scale encirclement exercises named JOINT SWORD-2024A (May) and 2024B (October).	Practiced simulated blockade scenarios against Taiwan's primary commercial ports and demonstrated rapid joint-force mobilization.
2025–2026	The PLA normalizes "grey-zone" operations: Coast Guard patrols into Taiwan's restricted waters, drone flights, and joint drills including STRAIT THUNDER-2025A .	Depletes Taiwanese military readiness through continuous alert cycles without crossing the threshold into full-scale war.
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KEY ISSUES AND FLASHPOINTS

Sovereignty and Political Status

The central issue remains Taiwan's political status.

Beijing maintains that Taiwan is part of China and that reunification is a national objective. Chinese official documents identify peaceful reunification as the preferred means of achieving this objective.

Taiwan, meanwhile, operates under its own democratic institutions and exercises de facto self-government.

The committee must therefore distinguish between:

- historical claims;
- constitutional claims;
- effective governance;
- international recognition;
- popular political identity; and
- international legal interpretation.

The One-China Principle

For Beijing, the One-China Principle includes the position that there is one China and Taiwan is part of China.

Military Deterrence and Escalation

The People's Liberation Army (PLA) has undergone extensive modernisation since the 1990s.

The study guide identifies developments in missile systems, naval capabilities, air power and cyber capabilities as important elements of the changing strategic balance.

Taiwan has simultaneously strengthened its defensive capabilities and security relationships.

This produces a **security dilemma**: actions described by one side as defensive may be interpreted by another as preparation for offensive action.

United States Involvement

American involvement represents one of the most important variables in a Taiwan crisis.

The United States maintains diplomatic relations with Beijing while continuing unofficial relations with Taiwan.

Its strategic ambiguity creates uncertainty regarding the precise circumstances under which Washington would intervene in a major crisis.

For the Chinese Cabinet, US involvement must therefore be considered not only as a military question but also as a diplomatic, economic and information problem.

Economic Interdependence

Cross-Strait trade and global economic integration create incentives for stability while simultaneously increasing the potential costs of disruption.

Taiwan's semiconductor industry is particularly significant.

The committee guide highlights Taiwan's role in global semiconductor production and the importance of advanced chips to modern industries.

A serious crisis could affect:

- semiconductor production;
- shipping;
- insurance;
- financial markets;
- technology exports;
- manufacturing;
- energy flows; and
- global supply chains.

International Recognition

Taiwan's participation in international organisations remains contested.

China argues that Taiwan cannot participate as a separate sovereign state in organisations where statehood is a membership requirement. Other governments have sought various forms of Taiwan's participation in international institutions without formally recognising Taiwan as an independent state.

This creates a diplomatic balancing problem.

Humanitarian Consequences

A major crisis would affect civilians regardless of the political outcome.

Potential concerns include:

- civilian displacement;
- disruption of food and energy supplies;
- medical shortages;
- evacuation;
- maritime safety;
- communication disruptions;
- protection of critical infrastructure; and
- international humanitarian coordination.

The humanitarian dimension should therefore remain separate from political arguments about sovereignty.

CASE STUDIES

1. The Semiconductor Industry and Economic Interdependence

The Taiwan Strait dispute is no longer solely a question of territory, sovereignty or military security. Taiwan's importance to the global semiconductor industry has given the crisis a major economic and technological dimension.

Taiwan is a major centre of advanced semiconductor manufacturing, particularly through the Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing Company (TSMC). Semiconductors are essential components in smartphones, automobiles, artificial intelligence systems, computers and numerous other technologies.

This creates a situation in which instability around Taiwan could affect economies far beyond East Asia. Military escalation, disruption to shipping, sanctions, trade restrictions or a blockade could interfere with the movement or production of critical components.

At the same time, economic integration has not eliminated political distrust. During the 2000s, Taiwanese businesses expanded investment and manufacturing links with mainland China. Cross-Strait economic connections consequently became extensive.

2. Blockade-Style Exercises, 2022–2025

Since the 2022 Pelosi visit the PLA has followed a recognisable pattern. A political trigger, such as a US-Taiwan contact, an inauguration, a speech or an arms sale, is followed by a short, named exercise, usually one to two days long. Exercises simulate blockade of ports and energy infrastructure, use the China Coast Guard alongside the PLA, and are accompanied by propaganda aimed at the Taiwanese public and the Lai government.

Successive exercises have moved closer to Taiwan: Joint Sword-2024A and 2024B (2024), Strait Thunder-2025A (April 2025) and Justice Mission-2025 (December 2025), when missiles landed in Taiwan's contiguous zone. Because Beijing has said it will respond to each 'provocation', analysts note that it is unclear how a future exercise could escalate further without crossing a threshold that risks a wider crisis.

For the Chinese Cabinet, exercises are a tool of calibrated signalling. Their value depends on whether they change Taiwanese, American or Japanese behaviour, or instead harden it. Delegates should weigh what each exercise is intended to communicate, what it might unintentionally provoke, and what response would leave Beijing with room to de-escalate.

CRISIS MANAGEMENT FRAMEWORK

The Chinese Cabinet should approach the crisis through **five interconnected layers**.

1. INFORMATION

Determine what is known, what is uncertain and what may be deliberately misleading.

2. POLITICS

Assess the domestic political consequences of every major decision.

3. DIPLOMACY

Determine how China can communicate with Taiwan and third-party states while preserving its stated political position.

4. SECURITY

Evaluate deterrence, military readiness, escalation risks and the possibility of miscalculation.

5. ECONOMICS

Consider sanctions, trade disruption, semiconductor supply, financial stability and shipping.

These layers should never be treated independently.

DIRECTIVE (TEMPLATES)

TEMPLATE 1: CABINET DIRECTIVE

DIRECTIVE TITLE: Operation Iron Shield (Strategic Port Defense)

SUBMITTED BY: Minister of National Defense, Navy Commander, Minister of Economic Affairs

SITUATION SUMMARY: PLA naval vessels have established a cordon 30nm from Kaohsiung.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE: Re-open commercial shipping lane to ensure energy imports without initiating combat.

OPERATIONAL MEASURES:

1. Deploy Coast Guard cutters to lead commercial LNG tankers through recognized safe sea lanes.
 2. Station Navy corvettes at a 15nm defensive perimeter with coastal radar tracking enabled.
 3. Establish a live video feed to broadcast all interactions to international maritime observers.
-

RESOURCES REQUIRED: 4 Coast Guard patrol vessels, 2 Tuo Chiang-class corvettes, Kaohsiung Port Authority.

EXPECTED OUTCOME: Safely dock LNG cargo while deterring boarding actions through public transparency.

TEMPLATE 2: PORTFOLIO ACTION ORDER

ACTION ORDER: MOEA-2028-04

TO: Bureau of Energy, Taiwan Power Company (Taipower), Crisis Staff

FROM: Minister of Economic Affairs

SUBJECT: Phase 1 National Energy Conservation & Reserve Allocation

MANDATE ACTION: Release 10% of strategic petroleum reserves to critical power generators; mandate non-essential industrial energy cuts during peak hours to preserve LNG stockpiles for 18 days.

RESOURCES: National Petroleum Strategic Reserve Facilities, Taipower dispatch center.

POTENTIAL RISK: Temporary 4% dip in non-essential manufacturing

output; public market unease.

SIGNATURE: [Minister of Economic Affairs]

TEMPLATE 3: SUBSTANTIVE CRISIS CHIT

TO: Crisis Staff (Intelligence & Maritime Desk)

FROM: Director-General, National Security Bureau (NSB)

CLASSIFICATION: TOP SECRET // CABINET EYES ONLY

MESSAGE: Request immediate satellite confirmation regarding the true loading manifests of Chinese maritime militia vessels off Pratas Island.

INFORMATION REQUESTED: Are these vessels carrying armed personnel and water cannons, or are they standard civilian trawlers acting as visual pickets?

DISCRETE ACTION: Task two high-altitude maritime reconnaissance drones to photograph deck equipment from international airspace.

PRIORITY: HIGH (Requires response within 20 minutes for Cabinet briefing)

AREAS FOR FURTHER RESEARCH

Primary Sources

- UN General Assembly Resolution 2758
- UN Charter
- Taiwan Relations Act
- Chinese government white papers on Taiwan
- China-US Joint Communiqués
- Official statements concerning cross-Strait relations

Historical Research

- Chinese Civil War
- First Taiwan Strait Crisis
- Second Taiwan Strait Crisis
- Third Taiwan Strait Crisis
- Taiwan's democratisation
- Cross-Strait economic integration

Strategic Research

- PLA modernisation
- Taiwan's defence policy
- US strategic ambiguity
- Japan's regional security policy
- First Island Chain
- Maritime security

Economic Research

- Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing Company (TSMC)
- semiconductor supply chains
- shipping through East Asian maritime routes
- sanctions and export controls
- China-Taiwan trade

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